

# Lab 4 - Set Up Grids, Guides and a Modular Column Structure

Topic 01: Get Started on InDesign | LO1 | TGS-2021007827

## The Situation

The Harmony Petals brochure has come back from the client with one comment: "It looks untidy - the pictures and the headings don't line up." Priya wants the two product photographs aligned exactly and the whole page built on a repeatable structure so that the next six brochures in the series look like a family rather than six unrelated documents.

## At a Glance

|                       |                                                                                                                                                                         |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Learning outcome      | LO1                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Objective             | Determine document dimensions and structure by building a baseline grid, a document grid and a modular guide system that aligns every element on the page (TSC A2, A4). |
| You will produce      | HP_Brochure_1.indd with a 12 pt baseline grid, a 3-column x 4-row modular grid with 4 mm gutters, and the two product images aligned exactly to the grid.               |
| Tools and panels      | Adobe InDesign   Preferences > Grids   Layout > Create Guides   Ruler guides   Smart Guides                                                                             |
| Starter InDesign file | HP_Brochure_1.indd                                                                                                                                                      |
| Final filename        | Lab-04-Completed.indd                                                                                                                                                   |

## What You Will Do

Diagnose why an unaligned page reads as untidy, then build the invisible skeleton that fixes it: a baseline grid for the type, a document grid for objects, ruler guides for specific positions, and a full modular grid created in one dialog with Layout > Create Guides.

## Phase 1 - Prepare and Baseline

1. Read this guide completely, then duplicate HP\_Brochure\_1.indd as Lab-04-Working.indd.
2. Create an Evidence/ folder beside the working file.
3. Open the working copy and capture the starting Pages, Links or Preflight panel most relevant to the task.
4. Keep every linked asset inside this lab folder; never relink to Downloads, Desktop or a network path.

Starter role: Brochure starter for baseline grids, guides and modular alignment.

## Phase 2 - Build

### Step-by-Step Procedure

1. Open HP\_Brochure\_1.indd from the Topic 1 lab folder and assess the current alignment of the two images.

Open HP\_Brochure\_1.indd

2. Choose Preferences > Grids. Set the baseline grid Start at 0 mm, Relative To Top Margin, and Increment Every 12 pt to match a 12 pt body leading.

Preferences > Grids | Increment Every 12 pt

3. In the same dialog set the Document Grid to 5 mm gridline spacing with 5 subdivisions.

Document Grid: 5 mm, 5 subdivisions

4. Show the grids with View > Grids & Guides > Show Baseline Grid and Show Document Grid.

View > Grids & Guides > Show Baseline Grid

5. Choose Layout > Create Guides. Set Rows 4, Row Gutter 4 mm, Columns 3, Column Gutter 4 mm, Fit Guides to Margins, and tick Remove Existing Ruler Guides.

Layout > Create Guides | 4 rows / 3 columns / 4 mm gutters

6. Drag a horizontal ruler guide from the top ruler to sit exactly on the second row line; note the Y value in the Control panel as you drag.

7. Drag from the ruler with the pointer over the pasteboard to create a spread guide, and compare its extent with the page guide you just made.

8. Enable View > Grids & Guides > Snap to Guides, then drag the first product image so its top-left corner snaps to a grid intersection.

View > Grids & Guides > Snap to Guides

9. Drag the second image and use the green Smart Guides to align its top edge and its vertical centre with the first image.

10. Select both images, open Window > Object & Layout > Align, and click Align Top Edges then Distribute Horizontal Centers to confirm the alignment numerically.

Window > Object & Layout > Align

11. Press W for Preview and confirm the page now reads as ordered, with no visible guides.

W = Preview

## Verify Your Work

- ☐ Done when: Both images sit exactly on grid intersections, the Align panel confirms their top edges match, and the page shows a consistent 3 x 4 modular structure with 4 mm gutters.

## Evidence and Submission

- [ ] Updated HP\_Brochure\_1.indd
- [ ] Grid and guide settings screenshot
- [ ] 100 percent alignment proof
- [ ] Final native file saved as Lab-04-Completed.indd
- [ ] All linked assets remain inside this lab folder or its subfolders
- [ ] No overset text, missing fonts or missing links remain unless the task explicitly asks you to diagnose them

## Recovery Path

1. If the working file is damaged, close it without saving and duplicate HP\_Brochure\_1.indd again.
2. If links are missing, use the Links panel Relink command and select the matching file inside this lab folder.
3. If fonts are missing, activate Adobe Fonts or substitute an approved font, then check for reflow and overset text.

4. Re-run the verification gate and recapture evidence after recovery.

## If It Doesn't Work

Objects will not snap? Snap to Guides is off, or you are zoomed too far out for the snap zone to engage - zoom to at least 100%. Baseline grid not visible? It only displays above a threshold zoom set in Preferences > Grids > View Threshold.

## Stretch Challenge

Create an alternate four-column layout and use Adjust Layout to compare what reflows automatically and what still needs manual correction.

## Discussion Questions

1. What is the difference between a baseline grid and a document grid, and what does each one align?
2. Why should the baseline grid increment match the leading of your body text?
3. State the difference between a page guide and a spread guide, and how you create each one.
4. Layout > Create Guides asks for Number and Gutter. If a 190 mm text area is divided into 3 columns with 4 mm gutters, how wide is each column?
5. Grids and guides never print. Why, then, are they considered a production requirement rather than a personal preference?

## Reference Artwork

[!Lab 4](#)

## Reference Basis

ACP guide domains 2 and 3: rulers, guides, grids, margins, columns and precise object alignment.

Current Adobe Help: <https://helpx.adobe.com/indesign/desktop.html>

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